

Process Paper: The Running Revolution: How Oregon Shaped Fitness

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Exhibit Category

Junior Division

Individual

Process Paper: 477 Words

Exhibit: 500 Words

How I Chose My Topic and How It Relates to the Theme

I chose to learn about the history of running because I'm a die-hard running fan and it is very special to me. I also grew up in Oregon and run for Bowerman Track Club. I was interested in how running became so popular and why millions of people jog every day like me. I thought it was a great topic for the theme of Revolution, Reaction, and Reform because there was a really big change in culture in a short amount of time.

How I Conducted My Research

I started my research with background reading about the rise of jogging and fitness from popular magazine articles given to me by parents. I summarized them and then looked for primary sources that backed up those histories.

I read the book Jogging by Bill Bowerman and W.E Harris. I learned that the focus of this book was really about getting people to start jogging, not to make athletes. It was surprising to see that my own training is so much more difficult than what he recommended, but it also makes sense because he just wanted to get people to start running.

Another book I read in part was Shoe Dog, by Phil Knight. From this book, I learned that people were once really discouraged to run. I wouldn't have wanted to run either if people were yelling at me on the streets. It made me realize that things have to be accepted before people want to participate.

After reading several articles, I was impressed that people considered running clubs as newsworthy and that so many people joined so quickly. It was interesting to see how popular this race became so quickly and how so many other cities followed its lead.

How I Created My Project

I organized my exhibit into three panels. The first panel shows what it was like to be a runner before the revolution. The second panel is about actions Bill Bowerman and Nike took to popularize the sport and icons like Prefontaine who people idolized. The third panel is about the growth of the sport and what running is like today.

My Historical Argument

My argument is that The Running Revolution was started by Bill Bowerman, an Oregon track coach. He wrote an important book, started running clubs, and co-founded Nike. Nike made the sport comfortable by making shoes and started community races. Together, these actions kickstarted the Running Revolution.

Why This Topic Is Significant

Running became one of the most popular sports and tens of millions now run everyday. It is the most popular girls high school sport and second on the boy's side. Today it's normal to see people running every day. If you are a runner or want to be, there are opportunities for everyone, due to the Running Revolution.

Annotated Bibliography

Primary Sources

Bowerman, William J and W. E. Harris. 1967. *Jogging*. New York: Grosset & Dunlap.

- This book showed me how Bill Bowerman introduced jogging to people.

Knight, Phil. *Shoe Dog: A Memoir by the Creator of Nike*. New York: Scribner, 2016.

- This source helped me confirm that running was for wierdos, explained Bill Bowerman's role in Nike, and described shoe sales.

Collection from *NewsBank America's News*. Oregon newspapers, 1950–1980. Search term: "jogging." Accessed February 2026. <https://infoweb.newsbank.com>.

- These articles taught me about the rise of running clubs.

Collection from *Register-Guard* (Eugene, OR), search: "Butte to Butte," all years, Google News Archive, accessed February 2026 <https://news.google.com/newspapers>.

- These articles showed by the growth of popularity of road races from one of the first races in the country.

Secondary Sources

Anderson, Jakob. "The State of US Marathons 2025." RunRepeat. August 28, 2025. <https://runrepeat.com/the-state-of-us-marathons-2025>.

- This gave me statistics on the rise of road races.

Hefferman, Connor. "Born to Run: The Origins of America's Jogging Craze." Physical Culture Study, June 15, 2015. <https://physicalculturestudy.com/2015/06/15/born-to-run-the-origins-of-americas-jogging-craze/>.

- This article helped me see that running really became fashionable.

Friedman, Danielle. "1972–1982: The Decade That Changed Fitness Forever." *The New York Times*, January 14, 2025.

- This article helped me first learn about the revolution.

Lathan, S Robert. "A history of jogging and running-the boom of the 1970s." *Proceedings (Baylor University. Medical Center)* vol. 36,6 775-777. 15 Sep. 2023.

- This gave me a broad overview of the history, that jogging became popular first and then race popularity came second.